1. Basic facts

Full name and other names

- **Full name: Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan** | The Tribune | "Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, also known as 'Bacha Khan' or the 'Frontier Gandhi,'"
-
- **Other names: Badshah Khan ("King of Chiefs"), shortened to Bacha Khan** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "It was in this frenzied activity that he had come to be known as Badshah Khan ("King of Chiefs"), which was later shortened to Bacha Khan."
-
- **Other names: Fakhr-e-Afghan ("Pride of the Afghans") and Frontier Gandhi (*Sarhadi Gandhi*)** | Pashtoonkhwa | "However, his own people gave him three titles--Fakhr-e-Afghan, Bacha Khan and the Frontier Gandhi"
-

Born and died

- **Born (Version A — 6 February 1890): Born on 6 February 1890 in Utmanzai, Hashtnagar, Punjab Province, British India (now in Charsadda District, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan)** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Abdul Ghaffar Khan was born on 6 February 1890 into a prosperous Sunni Muslim Muhammadzai Pashtun family from Utmanzai, Hashtnagar"
-
- **Born (Version B — 1890 according to school records, exact day unrecorded):** Encyclopædia Britannica, the Constitution of India archive, and Pashtoonkhwa give his birth year simply as 1890 based on school records. | Pashtoonkhwa | "Abdul Ghaffar was born into an aristocratic family of Utmanzai, Hasht-nagar, in 1890, according to school records."
-
- **Died: 20 January 1988 in Peshawar, Pakistan (at age 97 or 98) from complications of a stroke, and buried on 22 January 1988 at his home in Jalalabad, Afghanistan** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Bacha Khan died in Peshawar in 1988 from complications of a stroke and was buried in his house at Jalalabad, Afghanistan."
-

Family, education, work

- **Father and brother: Son of landowner Abdul Bahram Khan and younger brother of Dr. Khan Abdul Jabbar Khan (Dr. Khan Sahib)** | Pashtoonkhwa | "He was the second and last son of Bahram Khan who was then known as the Mashar Khan (the great Khan or the Khan of Khans). Bahram's first son was Dr. Khan Sahib."
-
- **First marriage and children: Married Meharqanda Kinankhel in 1912 (she died in the 1918 influenza epidemic, or December 1915 in some accounts); their children were poet Abdul Ghani Khan, politician Abdul Wali Khan, and daughter Sardaro** |

Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "He married his first wife, Meharqanda, in 1912... They had a son in 1913, Abdul Ghani Khan... another son, Abdul Wali Khan (17 January 1917 – 2006), and daughter, Sardaro. Meharqanda died during the 1918 influenza epidemic."

- **Second marriage and children: Married Nambata Kinankhel in 1920 (she died in 1926 after falling down stairs in Jerusalem); their children were daughter Mehar Taj and educator Abdul Ali Khan** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "In 1920, Bacha Khan remarried; his new wife, Nambata... They had a daughter, Mehar Taj (25 May 1921 – 29 April 2012), and a son, Abdul Ali Khan (20 August 1922 – 19 February 1997)."
- **Education: Studied the Quran at a local mosque, attended Municipal Board High School and Edwardes Memorial Mission High School in Peshawar under Headmaster Rev. E. F. E. Wigram, and studied at Campbellpur, Qadian, and Aligarh Muslim University** | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "He was, then, sent to the Municipal Board High School and later to Edwardes Memorial Mission High School at Peshawar, where the Rev. E F E Wigram was his headmaster."
- **Work: Educator, social reformer, founder of the *Pakhtun* monthly journal (1928) and the nonviolent *Khudai Khidmatgar* movement (1929), and Member of the Constituent Assembly of India (1946–1947) and later of Pakistan (1948)** | Constitution of India Archive | "At the age of twenty, he founded the first of several schools... In 1929, he began the non-violent Khudai Khitmatgar or Red Shirt Movement."

Groups and organisations they belonged to

- **Azad Islamia Schools network (founded starting in 1910 in Utmanzai with Haji Sahib of Turangzai)** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "At the age of 20 in 1910, Khan opened a madrasa in his hometown of Utmanzai. In 1911, he joined the independence movement of the Pashtun activist Haji Sahib of Turangzai."
- **Khilafat Committee in the North-West Frontier Province (President, 1921)** | Encyclopædia Britannica | "In the following year he joined the Khilafat movement... and in 1921 he was elected president of a district Khilafat committee in his native North-West Frontier Province."
- **Anjuman-e-Islah-ul-Afaghina ("Afghan Reform Society", founded 1921) and Pakhtun Jirga (founded 1927)** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "This led to the formation of the Anjuman-e Islāh-e Afghānia (Pashto: انجمن اصلاح افاغنه, 'Afghan Reform Society') in 1921, and the youth movement Paxtūn Jirga"

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- **Khudai Khidmatgar ("Servants of God" / "Red Shirts", founded 1929)** | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "Khudai Khidmatgar (Pashto: خدای خدمتگار, lit. 'servants of God') was an Indian, predominantly Pashtun, nonviolent resistance movement"
-
- **Indian National Congress (Working Committee member, 1931–1947) and All-India Village Industries Association** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "He remained a member of the Congress Working Committee for many years, resigning only in 1939 because of his differences with the Party's War Policy."
-
- **Constituent Assembly of India (Member from North-West Frontier Province, 1946–1947)** | Constitution of India Archive | "Khan was elected to the Constituent Assembly from the North West Frontier Province on a Congress party ticket."
-
- **Pakistan Azad Party (founded May 1948), National Awami Party (1957–1986), and Awami National Party (1986–1988)** | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Following this, Bacha Khan formed Pakistan's first national opposition party, on 8 May 1948, the Pakistan Azad Party."
-

The 5 to 10 most important events in their life (in date order)

1. **1906–1909 — Refused a commission in the British Indian Army's Corps of Guides and gave up going to London:** Turned down an officer's commission after seeing a British officer insult an Indian officer, and later stayed back from studying engineering in London at his mother's request. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "He saw an English officer insulting an Indian senior in age. The insolent behaviour of the officer upset him so much that he ultimately decided not to enter the military career."
2.
3. **1910–1915 — Opened his first school in Utmanzai at age 20 and visited 500 villages:** Established a network of schools in the North-West Frontier Province before the British shut them down in 1915 and arrested the teachers; between 1915 and 1918 he walked through 500 villages preaching education and social reform, earning the name "Badshah Khan" ("Bacha Khan"). | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Between 1915 and 1918 he visited 500 villages in all part of the settled districts of NWFP. It was in this frenzied activity that he had come to be known as Badshah Khan"
4.
5. **1919–1924 — Protested the Rowlatt Act, led the Khilafat Movement on the Frontier, and endured three years in prison:** Organised protests against the 1919 Rowlatt Act, met Mahatma Gandhi, founded the Anjuman-e-Islah-ul-Afaghina in 1921, and was imprisoned from 1921 to 1924. | Encyclopædia Britannica | "Ghaffar Khan met Gandhi and entered politics in 1919 during agitation over the Rowlatt Acts"
6.
7. **May 1928 – November 1929 — Launched the Pashto monthly *Pakhtun* and founded**

the *Khudai Khidmatgar* ("Red Shirts"): Started the Pashto magazine *Pakhtun* in May 1928 and formed the nonviolent *Khudai Khidmatgar* ("Servants of God") army in 1929, which grew to 100,000 unarmed volunteers. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "After Khan's return from the Islamic Hajj pilgrimage to Mecca, Hejaz−Nejd (present-day Saudi Arabia) in May 1928, he founded the Pashto-language monthly political journal Paxtūn... Finally, in November 1929, Khan founded the Khudāyī Khidmatgār"

8.
9. **23 April 1930 — Arrested on the day of the Qissa Khwani Bazaar Massacre in Peshawar:** After his arrest during the Salt Satyagraha on 23 April 1930, British armoured cars and machine guns killed between 20 (official British count) and 200–400 (Indian and Pakistani estimates) unarmed Khudai Khidmatgar protesters in Peshawar's Qissa Khwani Bazaar, while two platoons of the Royal Garhwal Rifles under Chandra Singh Garhwali refused orders to shoot. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "The Qissa Khwani massacre... on 23 April 1930 was an armoured vehicle-ramming attack and mass shooting of the unarmed civilian freedom fighters by the British colonial troops"
10.
11. **August 1931 & 1934 — Allied the Khudai Khidmatgar with the Indian National Congress and declined the Congress Presidency:** Formally allied the Khudai Khidmatgar with the Congress in August 1931 and turned down offers to become Congress President (saying he wanted to remain a simple soldier), living at Gandhi's Wardha ashram while exiled from the Frontier until August 1937. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "Abdul Ghaffar Khan issued a statement in which he said: 'Let me declare, as I have done over and over again, that I am only a humble soldier and it is my ambition to end my days not as a general but as a soldier.'"
12.
13. **May & October 1938 — Hosted Mahatma Gandhi on a tour of the North-West Frontier Province:** Walked across the Frontier districts with Mahatma Gandhi in 1938 to inspect the nonviolent Khudai Khidmatgar volunteers. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "he entered his homeland after six years of exile... It was followed by a visit from Gandhi between 1 and 8 of May 1938."
14.
15. **June–July 1947 — Opposed the Partition of India, issued the Bannu Resolution, and boycotted the NWFP referendum:** Objected when the Congress Working Committee accepted the 3 June 1947 Partition plan (telling Congress leaders, "you have thrown us to the wolves"), called the Bannu *loya jirga* on 21 June 1947 to demand an option for an independent Pashtunistan, and boycotted the July 1947 referendum when the British refused that option. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "When the Indian National Congress reluctantly declared its acceptance of the partition plan without consulting the Khudai Khidmatgar leaders, he felt deeply betrayed, telling the Congress leaders "you have thrown us to the wolves.""
16.

17. **1948–1988 — Imprisoned for 15–17 years in Pakistan, lived in exile in Afghanistan, and received the Bharat Ratna (1987):** Took the oath of allegiance to Pakistan in February 1948, spent roughly 15 to 17 years in Pakistani prisons and years of exile in Afghanistan (1964–1972), visited India in 1969 to receive the Jawaharlal Nehru Award, became the first non-Indian citizen to receive the Bharat Ratna in 1987, and died on 20 January 1988. | Constitution of India Archive | "His activism in Pakistan resulted in repeated imprisonment over the course of seventeen years... In 1987, he became the first non-Indian to be awarded India's highest civilian honour, the Bharat Ratna."
18.

2. Story angles (at least 10)

Angle 1: The Haircut Insult That Cost the British Army a Recruit

- **One-line hook:** Teenaged Abdul Ghaffar was already picked to become an elite cavalry officer in the British Indian Army—until he watched an English lieutenant mock an older Indian officer in camp.
-
- **Key facts:**
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    - While studying at Edwardes Memorial Mission High School in Peshawar, a family servant named Barani Kaka persuaded young Abdul Ghaffar to apply for a prestigious officer's commission in the elite Corps of Guides regiment stationed at Mardan. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "In November 1906, while Abdul Ghaffar was in his sixth class, a servant named Barani Kaka tried to persuade him to get into military profession. The persuasion bore fruit and Abdul Ghaffar applied for a Commission"
    -
    - Visiting the army camp, he saw a British officer insult an older Indian officer (mocking his parted hair), proving to him that even Indian officers in the Guides were treated as second-class citizens. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "He saw an English officer insulting an Indian senior in age. The insolent behaviour of the officer upset him so much that he ultimately decided not to enter the military career."
    -
    - He immediately walked away from the army commission and returned to his studies, and when his mother later cried at the thought of losing a second son to London (where his older brother Jabbar was studying medicine), he stayed home to open schools in Frontier villages instead. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "However, his mother wasn't willing to let another son go to London, so he began working on his father's lands in the process of figuring out his next steps."
    -

Angle 2: The Twenty-Year-Old Schoolbuilder Who Walked to 500 Villages

- **One-line hook:** At age 20, in a mountain region where both British officials and local mullahs said children shouldn't go to school, young Ghaffar Khan opened a classroom in his village and walked through 500 villages on foot.
-
- **Key facts:**
-
    - In 1910, at age 20, he opened his first school in his home village of Utmanzai, and went on to build a network of "Azad" schools open to both boys and girls across Peshawar and Mardan districts. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "At 20 years of age, Bacha Khan opened his first school in Utmanzai... He opened a series of "Azad" schools which were open to all, including girls."
    -
    - By 1915, British authorities shut down his school and arrested most of the teachers because they feared educated Pashtuns would challenge colonial rule. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "The Government, then, arrested most of the teachers of the schools run by the Haji and Abdul Ghaffar Khan."
    -
    - Undeterred, between 1915 and 1918 he travelled to 500 villages across the Frontier urging people to give up blood feuds and educate their children, after which villagers gathered in a mosque and named him *Badshah Khan* ("Bacha Khan", or King of Chiefs). | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Between 1915 and 1918 he visited 500 villages in all part of the settled districts of NWFP. It was in this frenzied activity that he had come to be known as Badshah Khan ("King of Chiefs")"
    -

Angle 3: How a Tub of Brick-Red Tannery Dye Created the "Red Shirts"

- **One-line hook:** Why did 100,000 unarmed Pashtun peace volunteers wear bright brick-red shirts? Not because of a political flag—but because their white cotton tunics kept getting dusty in the villages!
-
- **Key facts:**
-
    - When Bacha Khan formed the *Khudai Khidmatgar* ("Servants of God") in 1929 from graduates of his village schools, the volunteers originally wore plain white overshirts. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "They began by wearing a simple white overshirt, but the white was soon dirtied."
    -
    - Because white clothes got dirty quickly during village work, a couple of volunteers dipped their white shirts into a local leather tannery's vat of pine-bark and

brick-red dye; the colour was cheap and hid dirt so well that the whole movement adopted brick-red uniforms (while women volunteers wore black), earning the nickname *Surkh Posh* ("Red Shirts"). | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "A couple of men had their shirts dyed at the local tannery, and the brick-red colour proved a breakthrough, it was this distinctive colour that earned the Khudai khidmatgar movement activists the name "the Red shirts""

- Organised into disciplined platoons with their own bagpipe-and-drum bands and generals (*Jarnails*), none of the 100,000 volunteers carried a weapon, and every recruit had to swear an oath to forgive anyone who struck them and do at least two hours of free community work every day. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "The men wore red uniforms and the women black. They had drills, badges, a flag, the entire military hierarchy of rank and even a bagpipe corps... I promise to devote at least two hours a day to social work."

Angle 4: Six Hours in the Storytellers' Bazaar (Qissa Khwani, 23 April 1930)

- **One-line hook:** In Peshawar's famous "Bazaar of Storytellers," British armoured cars and machine guns fired for six hours from 11 AM to 5 PM, yet line after line of unarmed Red Shirts stepped forward without raising a hand.
- **Key facts:**
  - On 23 April 1930, after Bacha Khan and other leaders were arrested during the Salt Satyagraha, thousands of unarmed townspeople and Khudai Khidmatgars gathered in Peshawar's Qissa Khwani ("Storytellers'") Bazaar. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "On 23 April 1930, Ghaffar Khan was arrested after giving a speech in Utmanzai... After other Khudai Khidmatgar leaders were arrested, a large crowd of the group gathered at the Qissa Khwani bazaar."
  - British armoured cars drove into the crowd at high speed, and British officers ordered troops to open fire with machine guns from 11:00 AM until 5:00 PM; as those in the front row fell wounded, volunteers behind them dragged the injured back and stepped forward unarmed to take their place. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "The Anglo-Indian paper of Lahore, which represents the official view, itself wrote to the effect that the people came forward one after another to face the firing and when they fell wounded they were dragged back"
  - Khudai Khidmatgar volunteer Musharraf Din later recalled how volunteers bit their own shawls when run over by horses and cars so they would not even cry out in pain. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "The British sent their horses and cars

to run over us, but I took my shawl in my mouth to keep from screaming."

Angle 5: The Soldiers Who Put Down Their Rifles at Peshawar

- **One-line hook:** Ordered to ride into Peshawar and shoot unarmed protesters after the Qissa Khwani massacre, Havildar Major Chandra Singh Garhwali and two platoons of Hindu mountain soldiers refused to board the army buses.
- **Key facts:**
  - During the April 1930 crackdown in Peshawar, British commanders ordered two platoons of the Royal Garhwal Rifles—a decorated Hindu regiment from the Himalayan hills of Uttarakhand—to board buses for anti-riot firing duty against the Muslim Pashtun protesters. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "Two platoons of a respected British Indian Army regiment, the Royal Garhwal Rifles, refused to board buses that were to take them into Peshawar for anti-riot duty."
  - Led by Havildar Major Chandra Singh Garhwali, the soldiers refused to fire on unarmed countrymen, choosing court-martial and years of prison instead. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "The NCOs of the two platoons, including one led by Hawaldar Major Chandra Singh Garhwali, involved were sentenced to terms of up to eight years imprisonment."

Angle 6: "There Should Be One General Only" — Why He Refused to Be Called "Frontier Gandhi" or Congress President

- **One-line hook:** Millions of Indians called him the "Frontier Gandhi" and three times tried to make him President of the Indian National Congress, yet the tall Pashtun leader begged students in Calcutta to stop calling him by Gandhi's name.
- **Key facts:**
  - A Peshawar journalist originally from Uttarakhand, Pandit Amir Chand Bombwal (editor of *The Frontier Mail*), coined the nickname "Frontier Gandhi" (*Sarhadi Gandhi*) for Bacha Khan. | The Tribune | "Even in case of Khan Abul Gaffar Khan, it was revolutionary journalist of Frontier Mail newspaper Amir Chand Bambwal, who gave the title of Frontier Gandhi to Khan."
  - When students in Calcutta cheered him as "Frontier Gandhi" in October 1934, Bacha Khan asked them not to use that title, saying: "Mahatma Gandhi is our

general and there should be one general only. So do not add the name of Gandhi to my name." | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "Addressing the gathering he requested not to call him Frontier Gandhi for he believed that there should be only one Gandhi. He said, 'Mahatma Gandhi is our general and there should be one general only.'"

- When the Indian National Congress offered him its Presidency in 1931 and again in 1934 (three times in all), he refused every time, declaring: "I am a simple soldier and Khudai Khidmatgar, and I only want to serve." | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "In 1931 the Congress offered him the presidency of the party, but he refused saying, "I am a simple soldier and Khudai Khidmatgar, and I only want to serve.""

Angle 7: Reading the Bhagavad Gita, the Guru Granth Sahib, and the Bible in Prison

- **One-line hook:** Locked inside a British jail in the 1920s, the devout Muslim scholar used his prison years to read the holy books of Hindus, Sikhs, and Christians for the first time.
- **Key facts:**
  - After Bacha Khan opened Azad High School in Utmanzai and became president of the district Khilafat Committee in 1921, British authorities arrested him for touring the district to reopen shut-down village schools. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "Objection was raised to his touring the district and he was arrested."
  - While locked in prison between 1921 and 1924, he read the *Bhagavad Gita*, the *Guru Granth Sahib*, and the *Bible* alongside the *Quran*, and upon his release in 1924 he pledged to campaign for Hindu-Muslim-Sikh unity. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "During this imprisonment he read theGita for the first time along with the Granth Saheb and the Bible."

Angle 8: "You Have Thrown Us to the Wolves" — The Last Night With Gandhi in Delhi (1947)

- **One-line hook:** Running a high fever on his last night with Mahatma Gandhi in New Delhi before Partition, Bacha Khan refused medicine and stayed up until 10:30 PM massaging Gandhi's legs, knowing they might never see each other again.
- **Key facts:**

    - Even though Bacha Khan and his Khudai Khidmatgar movement had won the 1937 and 1946 elections in the North-West Frontier Province in alliance with the Congress, the Congress Working Committee accepted the June 1947 Partition plan, prompting Bacha Khan to tell them: "you have thrown us to the wolves." | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "When the Indian National Congress reluctantly declared its acceptance of the partition plan without consulting the Khudai Khidmatgar leaders, he felt deeply betrayed, telling the Congress leaders "you have thrown us to the wolves.""
    - On the final evening of Gandhi's stay in New Delhi before Bacha Khan returned to the Frontier, Bacha Khan had a fever but refused medicine and insisted on pressing Gandhi's legs until 10:30 PM as he had done for years. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "It was the last day of Gandhi's stay in New Delhi, Badshah Khan who was suffering from fever refused to take any medicine. He insisted upon pressing Gandhi's limbs at night as before."
    - When Gandhi tried to stop him from tiring himself, Bacha Khan replied: "It is last day. So let me. It will make me well... Before long we shall become aliens in Hindustan." | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "He insisted and said, "It is last day. So let me. It will make me well."... 'Before long we shall become aliens in Hindustan.'"

Angle 9: The 79-Year-Old Guest With a Cloth Bundle Under His Arm (1969) (PERSONAL MEMORY by Pakistan Embassy translator in Kabul)

- **One-line hook:** When 79-year-old Bacha Khan flew to India in 1969 for Mahatma Gandhi's 100th birthday, he refused to let governors carry his little bundle of clothes—and went on a three-day hunger strike in Ahmedabad to stop Hindu-Muslim riots.
-
- **Key facts:**
-
    - In October 1969, after spending roughly 15 years in Pakistani prisons and moving into exile in Afghanistan in December 1964, Bacha Khan visited India for Mahatma Gandhi's birth centenary and to receive the Jawaharlal Nehru Award for International Understanding. | Pashtoonkhwa | "In 1969, Bacha Khan went to India to attend the inaugural ceremony of the centenary of Gandhijee... the Indian government in 1969 conferred upon Bacha Khan the Jawaharlal Nehru award"
    -

- Travelling to Ahmedabad right after severe communal riots, he refused to hand his small cloth bundle of clothes to the state governor or any official, tucking it under his own arm as usual. | Pashtoonkhwa | "He did not give his bundle of clothes to the local governor or any government official and kept it, as usual, under his arm."
-
- When state officials tried to steer him only to peaceful neighbourhoods, he followed a local activist to a camp of displaced riot victims, asked India's leaders "Had Gandhijee taught you to treat your people like this?", and fasted for three days for peace. | Pashtoonkhwa | "There, he asked the ruling junta of India ; "Had Gandhijee taught you to treat your people like this?"... In protest, Bacha Khan kept fast for three days."
-

Angle 10: The One-Day Ceasefire Across the Khyber Pass (January 1988)

- **One-line hook:** When 98-year-old Bacha Khan died in 1988 in the middle of the Soviet-Afghan War, both warring armies stopped shooting for a day so 200,000 mourners could walk his coffin through the Khyber Pass.
-
- **Key facts:**
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  - In 1987, the Government of India awarded Bacha Khan the Bharat Ratna, making him the first non-Indian citizen to receive India's highest civilian honour. | Constitution of India Archive | "In 1987, he became the first non-Indian to be awarded India's highest civilian honour, the Bharat Ratna."
  -
  - When he died in Peshawar on 20 January 1988 after spending around 30 years of his life in British and Pakistani prisons, Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi flew to Peshawar to pay tribute and India declared five days of national mourning. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "The then Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi went to Peshawar, to pay his tributes to Bacha Khan... Additionally, the Indian government declared a five-day period of mourning in his honour."
  -
  - Fulfilling his wish to be buried in the garden of his house in Jalalabad, Afghanistan, over 200,000 mourners marched with his body from Peshawar through the Khyber Pass to Jalalabad on 22 January 1988 while both sides in the Soviet-Afghan War declared an immediate ceasefire for his burial. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Over 200,000 mourners attended his funeral, including the Afghan president Mohammad Najibullah... despite the heavy fighting at the time due to the Soviet–Afghan War, both sides, namely the Soviet–Afghan government coalition and the Afghan mujahideen, declared an immediate ceasefire to allow Khan's burial."

○

Which angle is the big "flagship" story, and why

- **Flagship story: Angle 3 ("How a Tub of Brick-Red Tannery Dye Created the 'Red Shirts'") paired with Angle 4 & Angle 5 ("Six Hours in the Storytellers' Bazaar" and "The Soldiers Who Put Down Their Rifles at Peshawar").**
-
- **Why:** For a 10-year-old reader, it is astonishing to learn that in a mountain region famous for rifles and family blood feuds, Bacha Khan built an army of 100,000 volunteers who had generals, bugles, bagpipes, and shirts dyed brick-red at a leather tannery—yet carried zero weapons and promised to do two hours of daily chores for others. Seeing those unarmed Red Shirts stand still in the "Storytellers' Bazaar" on 23 April 1930 until the Garhwal Rifles soldiers refused to shoot them shows nonviolent courage in action.
-

3. People and places connected

People and groups

- **Abdul Bahram Khan:** Bacha Khan's father, a landowner of the Muhammadzai Pashtun clan in Utmanzai.
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- **Dr. Khan Abdul Jabbar Khan (Dr. Khan Sahib):** Bacha Khan's elder brother, who studied medicine in London, led the political wing of the Khudai Khidmatgar movement, and served twice as Congress Chief Minister of the North-West Frontier Province (1937–1939 and 1945–1947).
-
- **Rev. E. F. E. Wigram:** Headmaster of Edwardes Memorial Mission High School in Peshawar, whose dedication to community service inspired young Abdul Ghaffar to open schools for his people.
-
- **Haji Sahib of Turangzai (Haji Abdul Wahid Sahib):** Pashtun freedom fighter and social reformer with whom 20-year-old Bacha Khan opened village schools starting in 1910–1911.
-
- **Meharqanda Kinankhel and Nambata Kinankhel:** Bacha Khan's first wife (married 1912) and second wife (married 1920), and mothers of his five children (Abdul Ghani Khan, Abdul Wali Khan, Sardaro, Mehar Taj, and Abdul Ali Khan).
-
- **Mahatma Gandhi:** Close friend and ally with whom Bacha Khan worked from 1920 until 1947, touring the Frontier together in 1938.
-
- **Pandit Amir Chand Bombwal:** Peshawar journalist (originally from Uttarakhand) and editor of *The Frontier Mail* who coined the nickname "Frontier Gandhi" for Bacha Khan and was jailed alongside him.
-

- **Havildar Major Chandra Singh Garhwali and the Royal Garhwal Rifles:** The commander and two platoons of Indian soldiers who refused British orders to fire on unarmed Khudai Khidmatgar protesters in Peshawar in April 1930.
- **Khudai Khidmatgar ("Servants of God" / *Surkh Posh* / "Red Shirts"):** The 100,000-strong nonviolent Pashtun movement founded by Bacha Khan in 1929.

Places and events

- **Utmanzai (Hashtnagar, Charsadda District, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa):** Bacha Khan's home village on the banks of the Jindee branch of the Swat River, where he was born in 1890 and opened his first school in 1910.
- **Edwardes Memorial Mission High School, Peshawar:** The missionary school in Peshawar where Bacha Khan studied as a boy.
- **Qissa Khwani Bazaar ("Storytellers' Bazaar"), Peshawar:** The market square in Peshawar where British armoured cars and machine guns attacked unarmed Khudai Khidmatgar demonstrators on 23 April 1930.
- **Wardha Ashram (Maharashtra):** Mahatma Gandhi's ashram where Bacha Khan and his children Mehar Taj and Abdul Ali lived while the British banned him from entering the Frontier Province in the 1930s.
- **Sardaryab (near Peshawar):** The headquarters center (*Markaz-e-Khudai Khidmatgaran*) built by the Khudai Khidmatgars in 1942 and demolished by the provincial government in September 1948.
- **Bannu (North-West Frontier Province):** Town where Bacha Khan and Pashtun leaders held a *loya jirga* on 21 June 1947 and passed the Bannu Resolution demanding the option of an independent Pashtunistan.
- **Khyber Pass and Jalalabad (Afghanistan):** The mountain pass through which 200,000 mourners carried Bacha Khan's coffin from Peshawar to his home garden in Jalalabad during a one-day ceasefire on 22 January 1988.

4. Disputes, legends and doubts

1. Exact birth date of Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan (6 February 1890 vs. unrecorded day in 1890)

- **Version A (6 February 1890):** Modern newspapers and Wikipedia give his exact date of birth as 6 February 1890. | The Tribune | "Born on February 6, 1890, in Utmanzai, Pakistan, he belonged to the Pashtun ethnic group."

-
- **Version B (Only the year 1890 from school records):** Encyclopædia Britannica, the Constitution of India archive, and Pashtoonkhwa give only the year 1890, noting that rural Pashtun families did not record exact birth dates and 1890 comes from his school admission records. | Pashtoonkhwa | "Abdul Ghaffar was born into an aristocratic family of Utmanzai, Hasht-nagar, in 1890, according to school records."
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2. Death toll in the Qissa Khwani Bazaar Massacre on 23 April 1930 (20 vs. 200–250 vs. 400)

- **Version A (Official British report — 20 killed):** British colonial authorities reported that 20 demonstrators were killed in the firing at Qissa Khwani Bazaar on 23 April 1930 (though British secretary Olaf Caroe's confidential note in the British Library records secretly sending away lorry-loads of bodies at night to prevent funeral protests). | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "Deaths: 20 demonstrators killed according to official reports... "During the night in this way we sent away seven or eight bodies in lorries.""
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- **Version B (200 to 250 killed):** The main Wikipedia biography of Abdul Ghaffar Khan cites an estimated 200 to 250 unarmed people killed by British machine-gun fire. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "The colonial government ordered troops to open fire with machine guns on the unarmed crowd, killing an estimated 200–250."
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- **Version C (Local Indian and Pakistani sources — up to 400 killed):** Local nationalist sources in India and Pakistan put the death toll at around 400 demonstrators killed. | Wikipedia – Qissa Khwani massacre | "Contemporary estimates put the death toll between the official count of 20 and the figure of 400 put forth by Pakistani and Indian sources."
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3. When and how did his first wife Meharqanda die? (December 1915 vs. 1918 influenza epidemic)

- **Version A (1918 influenza pandemic):** Wikipedia states that his first wife Meharqanda died during the 1918 worldwide influenza epidemic after the birth of their second son Abdul Wali Khan (born 17 January 1917) and daughter Sardaro. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Subsequently, they had another son, Abdul Wali Khan (17 January 1917 – 2006), and daughter, Sardaro. Meharqanda died during the 1918 influenza epidemic."
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- **Version B (December 1915, plus a FAMILY MEMORY / spiritual story of walking around her sick son's cot):** The MKGandhi.org biography (compiled from D. G. Tendulkar's 1967 biography) dates her death to December 1915 and relates the family story that when eldest son Ghani fell gravely ill, Meharqanda walked around his *charpai*

(cot) praying to Allah to transfer the boy's illness to herself, after which the boy recovered and she fell ill and died. | MKGandhi.org – Badshah Khan | "In December 1915, soon after the birth of Wali, his second son, his first son Ghani took ill... Ghani's mother came near him, walked around the Charpai and prayed in supplication to Allah to transfer her son's affliction and disease to her"

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4. Exact date when the Khudai Khidmatgar ("Red Shirts") was founded (November 1929 vs. March 1930)

- **Version A (November 1929):** Wikipedia's biography of Abdul Ghaffar Khan and Encyclopædia Britannica place the founding of the Khudai Khidmatgar in 1929 (specifically November 1929). | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "Finally, in November 1929, Khan founded the Khudāyī Khidmatgār (خدايي خدمتگار, 'Servants of God') movement"
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- **Version B (March 1930):** The "Genesis" section of the *Khudai Khidmatgar* Wikipedia article states that the Khudai Khidmatgar was formally organised in March 1930, just before the April 1930 Qissa Khwani Bazaar massacre. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "Finally in March 1930, almost on the eve of the Qissa Khwani Massacre the Khudai Khidmatgar were formed."
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5. Why did the Khudai Khidmatgars choose brick-red shirts? (Practical tannery dye vs. socialist symbol)

- **Version A (Practical reason — white shirts got dirty easily, and local pine-bark tannery dye was cheap and brick-red):** Volunteers first wore white tunics, which showed dirt quickly, so two men dyed their shirts in brick-red solution at a local leather tannery. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "They began by wearing a simple white overshirt, but the white was soon dirtied. A couple of men had their shirts dyed at the local tannery, and the brick-red colour proved a breakthrough"
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- **Version B (Symbolic link to anti-colonial revolutionary and socialist movements):** The same article notes that another reason given for choosing red was symbolic solidarity with anti-colonial revolutionary and socialist movements of the era. | Wikipedia – Khudai Khidmatgar | "Other reason for the choice of red color was a symbolic adherence of the anti-colonial movements to the revolutionary and socialist discourse."
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6. What did Bacha Khan mean by "Pashtunistan"? (An independent country vs. an autonomous renamed province within Pakistan)

- **Version A (June 1947 Bannu Resolution — an independent state outside Pakistan and India):** At the Bannu *loya jirga* on 21 June 1947, Bacha Khan and the Khudai Khidmatgars demanded that Pashtuns be given the choice of an independent state of

Pashtunistan rather than joining either India or Pakistan. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "The loya jirga issueud the Bannu Resolution, which demanded that the Pashtuns be given a choice to have an independent state of Pashtunistan composing all Pashtun territories of British India"

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- **Version B (February 1948 speech in Pakistan's Constituent Assembly and later statements — an autonomous province within Pakistan):** After taking the oath of allegiance to Pakistan on 23 February 1948, Bacha Khan told Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan that "Pashtunistan" was simply the ethno-linguistic name for the Pashtun province inside Pakistan, just like Punjab, Sindh, Bengal, and Balochistan. | Wikipedia – Abdul Ghaffar Khan | "When during his speech he was asked by the PM Liaquat Ali Khan about Pashtunistan, he replied that it was just a name for the Pashtun province in Pakistan, just as Punjab, Bengal, Sindh, and Baluchistan"
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7. When did Bacha Khan return to Pakistan from his exile in Afghanistan? (December 1971 vs. 25 December 1972)

- **Version A (December 1971 in Eknath Easwaran's biography):** Biographer Eknath Easwaran gives the date of Bacha Khan's return from Afghanistan to Pakistan as December 1971. | Pashtoonkhwa | "There is some confusion over this date. In Eknath Easwaran's book, Nonviolent Soldier of Islam, the date is given as December 1971."
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- **Version B (25 December 1972 in Afghan and Pakistani records):** Afghan writer Abdullah Bakhtanay Khidmatgar, Pakistani diplomatic accounts, Encyclopædia Britannica, and Wikipedia state that he returned across the Torkham border to Peshawar in December 1972 (specifically 25 December 1972). | Pashtoonkhwa | "On the 25th of December 1972, Bacha Khan returned to Peshawar... Abdullah Bakhtanay Khidmatgar... mentions on page 48 of his book Da Sole au Azadae Qahraman (The Hero of Peace and Freedom), published in Afghanistan in 1987, that he had returned in December 1972."
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5. Pictures

1. File:Gandhi at Peshawar meeting.jpg | Mahatma Gandhi and Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan at a public meeting in Peshawar | Date: 1938 | Licence: Public domain (in India, first published more than 60 years ago)
2.
3. File:Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan 1939.jpg | Photograph of Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan published in *The Modern Review* (photographed by Nirmal Kumar Bose) | Date: 1939 (September 1939) | Licence: Public domain (in India)
4.
5. File:Abdul Ghaffar Khan and Gandhi in 1940.jpg | Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan standing beside Mahatma Gandhi | Date: 1940 | Licence: Public domain (in India and the United

States)
6.
7. File:Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan.jpg | Portrait photograph of Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan | Date: 1940s | Licence: Public domain (in India, Pakistan, and the United States)
8.
9. File:Abdul Ghafar Khan, Nehru, and Sardar Patel 1946.jpg | Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan walking with Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel at Simla during the 1946 independence negotiations (photographed by Kulwant Roy) | Date: 1946 | Licence: Public domain (in India)
10.
11. File:Jawaharlal Nehru with Abdul Ghaffar Khan at Wana during his visit to North West Frontier Province in October 1946.jpg | Jawaharlal Nehru with Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan at Wana during their tour of the North-West Frontier Province | Date: October 1946 (Before the 1950s) | Licence: Public domain (in India)
12.

6. Sources used

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5. Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan: The Frontier Gandhi — Sanjay Khurana, *The Tribune* (21 January 2025)
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7. Uttarakhand journalist gave Frontier Gandhi title to Abdul Gaffar Khan, claims book — *The Tribune* (24 December 2015)
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31. File:Abdul Ghafar Khan, Nehru, and Sardar Patel 1946.jpg — Wikimedia Commons
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33. File:Jawaharlal Nehru with Abdul Ghaffar Khan at Wana during his visit to North West Frontier Province in October 1946.jpg — Wikimedia Commons